The American Revolution

When the American Revolution began, the British had a larger army and more resources at their disposal. However, a huge disadvantage came with long delays in communication. Ships generally took around seven weeks to sail from England to America. Messages had to be sent via letters because there were no phones or telecommunication devices available at the time.

Britain initially won some battles at Long Island and New York in 1776 which resulted in the withdrawal of Washington. In retaliation, the Americans won victories at Trenton and then Princeton. The British won at Brandywine in 1777 but Washington won at Saratoga the same year. British forces made their way down from Canada but were trapped by the Americans and had no choice but to give up.

The French believed that the British would lose the war and seized this opportunity to join the war against their long-time enemy. In 1778, France joined America in its fight against Britain and caused the British great difficulties in resupplying their army in America. The Spanish and the Dutch joined the fight in the next two years by allying themselves with the Americans. Britain was overwhelmed by so many nations fighting it and was forced to keep the majority of its army within European territory to protect its homeland.

Washington gained victories at Kings Mountain and then at Cowpens in 1780-1781. The British were under the leadership of Cornwallis who made the wrong decision to concentrate at Yorktown in Virginia. Their army became trapped on all sides: the French navy blocked the ocean and the Americans had lined up on land. Having no choice, the British surrendered and suffered a great loss. Although they had lost the war, the revolution carried on for another two years before it officially ended in 1783 with the signing of the Treaty of Paris.